

Weaponised Containers Could Trigger the Next Hormuz Shipping Crisis

October 2026 Alert



Kanan is monitoring intelligence indicating the **use of commercial or civilian ships to carry missiles, drones or military personnel by Iran** to further disrupt the Strait of Hormuz.

This is a projection for October, and not an active scenario.

Commercial shipping through the Strait of Hormuz is already operating under severe pressure. The number of reported attacks on commercial vessels increased through late September. At the same time, regular container traffic has narrowed sharply: AD Ports-linked feeder vessels now account for most container transits. ([UKMTO](#))

Iran has previously been linked to weapons concealed inside normal commercial containers and has separately demonstrated the ability to launch ballistic missiles from containerised systems at sea. ([UN Official Document System](#))

Why this deserves attention:

1. Commercial shipping is being pulled further into the conflict

Repeated attacks on merchant vessels have become strategic for Iran. UKMTO reported tankers and cargo vessels struck by unknown projectiles on multiple occasions during the second half of the month, including a cargo vessel left on fire and adrift on 23 September and another vessel struck while transiting Hormuz on 28 September.

Since container network is already thin. State-backed feeder vessels now conduct most container crossings through Hormuz; weekly volumes remain well below pre-conflict levels. (Lloyd's List) Iran has strong incentives to cause more disruptions to pressure the US.

2. Iran has used commercial containers to conceal weapons before

In 2014, a UN Panel of Experts documented the seizure of the Klos C. Inspectors found 40 M-302 rockets, 181 mortars and approximately 400,000 rounds of ammunition concealed inside shipping containers among bags of cement. The Panel recorded evidence that the containers carrying the weapons had been loaded at Bandar Abbas. (UN Official Document System)

In February 2024, the IRGC launched two Fateh-family ballistic missiles from launchers housed in containers aboard the Shahid Mahdavi, a converted commercial container ship. Janes independently documented the launch and the released footage.

3. The Chinese have begun stocking up on oil after months of not buying

Early in the crisis, China helped soften the global supply shock by sharply reducing crude imports. That changed in September. Beijing began competing aggressively for available oil, cutting its import reductions from roughly **5.5 million barrels per day to 2.5 million barrels per day** and paying substantial premiums for supply.

At the same time, China has reduced diesel exports by around **500,000 barrels per day**, despite being one of the world's largest refining centres. Instead of releasing more refined fuel into an already tight market, more supply is being retained domestically.

The implication is significant: China has moved from temporarily easing pressure on global energy markets to securing crude and fuel for itself. The source material interprets this as a sign that Beijing is preparing for a tighter and more volatile energy environment, which in turn adds further pressure to global oil and diesel availability. [S&P Global](#)

Why now

The Strait is already part of the bargaining structure between Washington and Tehran.

1. On 22 September, a senior Iranian official told Reuters that Iran could reopen Hormuz within seven days if the United States eased military pressure and lifted its blockade on Iranian ports. The statement directly connected commercial passage through the Strait with concessions from Washington. (Investing.com)
2. A second factor is approaching quickly. The next U.S. federal general election is scheduled for 3 November 2026. (FEC.gov)

Kanan assessment: The 3 November U.S. midterm elections increases the potential value of economic pressure.

- A disruption that raises oil, freight and goods costs would reach the U.S. domestic economy during a politically sensitive period.
- The relevant combination is straightforward:
 - Hormuz is already being used as leverage.
 - Commercial shipping is already under attack.
 - The remaining container network is narrower than normal.
 - The economic consequences of a further escalation could therefore travel well beyond the Gulf.

How one incident could become a shipping crisis

A weaponised commercial vessel would create a different problem from another missile or drone strike. Iran would not need to physically stop every ship.

If a confirmed incident forces commercial operators to reconsider whether vessels can be verified, insured and operated safely, traffic can restrict itself. War-risk insurance is already expensive: Lloyd's List reported premiums exceeding \$10 million for some high-risk VLCC transits earlier in the crisis. ([Lloyd's List](#))

Worst-case scenario

A confirmed attack from a platform previously treated as civilian traffic triggers emergency inspections, tighter naval procedures, restrictions on insurance capacity and withdrawal by the remaining commercial operators.

In a worst case, parts of Hormuz shipping could become commercially unviable without a physical blockade.

Potential business impact

Risk	What could happen	Potential business effect
Shipping capacity	Carriers reduce Gulf exposure; inspections slow transit	Fewer sailings, rolled cargo, longer lead times
Insurance	War-risk cover reprices or becomes harder to obtain	Higher landed cost; voyages become uneconomic
Containers	Feeder disruption creates equipment imbalance	Empty-container shortages and booking constraints
Energy & materials	Gulf traffic falls further	Higher energy, petrochemical and material costs
Production	Critical inputs arrive late	Milestone slippage and customer-delivery exposure
Working capital	Transit times and safety stocks increase	More cash tied in inventory and expedited logistics

Signals to Watch Out for:

The scenario remains a warning, not a confirmed operation. Businesses should therefore watch for evidence that moves it from a plausible escalation path toward execution.

Watch closely for:

1. Reports of missiles, drones, military personnel or related equipment discovered aboard ordinary merchant or feeder vessels.
2. Credible naval, port or satellite reporting connecting containerised weapons to civilian maritime traffic.
3. UKMTO, NAVCENT, MARAD or other maritime authorities specifically warning that

merchant vessels may be used as military platforms.

4. New boarding, pre-transit inspection or identification procedures for container vessels operating around Hormuz.
5. Material reductions in underwriting appetite would indicate that the security concern is becoming a commercial constraint.
6. Suspension by the small group of operators currently sustaining container traffic would materially increase the risk of wider equipment and capacity disruption.

If several of these signals begin appearing together, businesses should treat the scenario as materially more advanced than it is today.

Immediate preparedness

1. **Identify exposed orders.**
Which live production commitments rely on Gulf transit, Gulf-origin inputs or affected transshipment networks?
2. **Find the single points of failure.**
Which materials, suppliers or routes cannot be replaced within the required production window?
3. **Stress-test 7-, 14- and 30-day disruption.**
Identify where inventory runs out, milestones slip or customer delivery becomes exposed.
4. **Confirm alternatives before they are needed.**
Check carrier capacity, alternate routes, insurance availability and inventory options while intervention remains possible.

Kanan helps manufacturers identify which external disruptions could affect specific production commitments, which signals matter to those orders, and which interventions remain available before the risk reaches production.

For an order-specific exposure assessment, contact Kanan.

Important notice

This advisory presents an emerging risk thesis based on publicly available information and Kanan's analysis as of **30 September 2026**. The weaponised-commercial-vessel scenario described above has **not been confirmed and should not be treated as substantiated prediction**.

Maritime, military, insurance and carrier conditions can change rapidly. Businesses should continue to monitor official maritime-security advisories and guidance from their carriers, insurers and relevant authorities, and adjust decisions as new evidence emerges.